

STRANGE ADVENTURES ON OTHER WORLDS—

PLANET stories

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CAPTIVES *of the* THIEVE-STAR

A Novellet of Rich
and Lawless Galaxies

By JAMES H. SCHMITZ

Also H. B. FIFE

FRANK E. LONG

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK OPEN
INVITATION ***

OPEN INVITATION

A Short Story by H. B. FYFE

The problem was simple—or rather, simply stated: Zoya Lar-Tul must keep those nasty, aggressive little *Earthmen* from discovering the location of his home-star....

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As Ullo Dah-Gow waddled into the section communications chamber on Yaradir, second planet of Zillor, two of his four walking tentacles stuck slightly on a nearly dry spot.

"Fire and dry sand!" he swore at the technicians. "Can't you two even keep the footing decently moist?"

Without waiting for an answer, he made his way to the row of shallow mud tubs before the television screen. The operators aimed eyestalks at each other. Finally, Yado Nol-Moz, as junior, rose and went to the wall controls of the conditioner.

The assistant supervisor was relieved to see a thin sheet of water creep across the floor. He never knew when Yado or Viri Nol-Rin might choose to ignore him.

Which comes of old Ahnu loading this section with his nephews, he thought bitterly, forgetting that in his own office he already had a list of his own relatives prepared against the day when he should succeed to the post of Supervisor of Colonial Scouting for Sector 63.

The slap-slap of tentacles in the corridor announced the arrival of his superior. Ahnu Nol-Yev entered and lowered his thick body into the choicest of the mud tubs, which Ullo had prudently left free.

"Now, what's this urgent message?" he demanded, pointing one eyestalk at Ullo and fixing the other upon the screen above Viri's broad, bony head.

"A request for orders from scout Zoya Lar-Tul," answered Viri. "Assigned to ... let me see ... system LL-255-13."

"Did we have any report on that system?" asked Ahnu.

Yado produced the tape of a preliminary report and placed it on the speaker. The list of facts rolled out: number of planets ... number with sufficient water for colonization ... number of intelligent species—one, on third planet ... native nomenclature—star, *Sol*; own planet, *Earth*; others ... and so on.

"All right," wheezed Ahnu. "I remember now. Get hold of ... whatsisname ... Zoya!"

Viri manipulated his keys and knobs. The brief delay before an answering image appeared on the screen irritated Ahnu. The loose, coppery scales around his thick neck glinted with iridescent highlights as he puffed out his air-sacs.

"Dessication!" he snarled. "We bridge all those light-years with subspace waves for his benefit, and he can't be alert enough to—Got him now, Viri?"

The technician snapped the tip of a gripping tentacle in assent. Another Yaradirian looked out at them from the screen.

This one had obviously been roughing it; his scales were lubricated by only a minimum film of moisture, and he wore space harness on the lower part of his body.



To keep his walking tentacles wet, Ullo realized. He hasn't so much as a drop of water on the floor of that dive!

"Zoya Lar-Tul!" announced Viri.

"Stated simply," said Ahnu bluntly, "what is your trouble?"

"Stated simply, Great One," answered the scout, "I am in imminent danger of detection by natives of this system."

Ullo stiffened in his mud tub. He heard the *slurp* as the Supervisor splashed more mud upon the oozing floor.

"How is that?" demanded Ahnu, his throat again beginning to expand majestically.

"I fail to see," replied Zoya, "in what manner I could have avoided it, Great One. The natives, *Earthmen* in their own speech, have just discovered an inefficient form of our own interstellar subspace drive. They have gone exploring."

Might have known it, thought Ullo. *Just when I'm working up to a top rank, too!*

It sounded bad. Should they be unable to think Zoya out of his predicament, it might well mean new personnel all around. Ullo's only satisfaction was that Ahnu's relatives would be discharged before his own resignation was given him to sign.

Ahnu controlled himself.

"Give me a picture of your situation!" he commanded.

"To begin with, Great One, I chose to study the natives from a distance, as is usual. I left my subspace ship on the largest satellite of their sixth planet, which has several other moons and a beautiful set of rings that—"

"Kindly touch bottom!" Ahnu cut him off. "I am not interested in a local travelogue!"

"Even so, Great One. With my short-range rocket, I then established this base on the seventh moon of their fifth planet. Only this moon's smallness and insignificance has so far prevented by discovery."

They listened to the rest of the story in an uncomfortable silence that was broken only by an occasional squishing of mud as one or another stirred uneasily.

Zoya Lar-Tul had observed the *Earthmen*, as well as other bodies in the system, for a quarter-revolution of his chosen fifth planet. At the time of his arrival, the natives had reached their own satellite, but he judged that they would be long in organizing successful flights to the planets.

"I translated some of their broadcasts and learned that this was their great current project. Naturally, however, I was unconcerned, and contented

myself with obtaining specimens for my researches by brief, discreet trips here and there."

Ullo snapped his tentacle tip quietly in assent. He remembered from his history the dreadfully long period of his own race's expansion throughout the system of Zillor. These *Earthmen*, however, seemed from Zoya's report to possess certain advantages. Their requirements of air and water were moderate and more easily stored in a space vessel. If they *had* discovered a form of subspace drive, they might be energetic enough to pop up in the vicinity of Zillor some fine day.

"You will imagine my amazement," continued Zoya, "when I heard one of their broadcasts announce that a ship had reached their fourth planet, and another the second—"

Ahnu blew out a long, bubbling breath.

"All this is doubtless interesting," he snorted, "but what is the immediate emergency?"

The image of Zoya aimed both eyestalks rather deliberately at the Supervisor.

"They reached and passed this group of satellites," he hissed out. "Do I make clear my dilemma, Great One?"

He waited while Ahnu's neck swelled dangerously. Just before the explosion, he continued:

"Should they discover me, they will also find the specimens I have collected, except the choicer ones stored on my subspace vessel for transport home. This is what I mean—"

Zoya reached out to touch a button, and the scene changed to what was evidently the dissecting laboratory of his base. Behind a transparent bulkhead hung several sorts of carcasses in various stages of dismemberment. Ullo suspected that the storeroom was simply left at the temperature of the moon's surface.

"Very well!" exclaimed Ahnu as the scout reappeared. "You seem to be operating a sort of butcher shop with some of the most ugly specimens ever seen. What about it?"

Ullo felt sorry for the scout. Even he—indeed, as he saw by the twitch of their eyestalks, even the technicians—had realized the problem. Zoya patiently explained, forbearing to mention that his instructions were laid out by Ahnu.

"If you will refer to descriptions in my preliminary report, Great One, you will see that certain of the specimens are *Earthmen* themselves. Should their explorers discover them, I have reason to believe they would be resentful. It is my opinion that they are a belligerent race."

Ahnu was silent for a moment.

"Well ... yes ... that is possible," he admitted.

"It would appear," he continued in another moment, "that you must either abandon your base or dispose of your specimens if, as you say, the *Earthmen* have so soon reached your vicinity."

Zoya waited. Ullo stirred in his tub.

"If I may suggest, Great One—?"

"Yes?"

"I believe he should destroy his subspace ship!"

"What!"

"I am inclined to agree," Zoya Lar-Tul put in.

Amazed, Ahnu waited for Ullo's reasons. Encouraged by such consideration, the latter went on.

"If these *Earthmen* are already on their way to the ringed planet, they will undoubtedly stop first at the largest moon—where Zoya has left his main ship."

"And will likely discover it there," Ahnu agreed reluctantly.

"And from that point," continued Ullo, "they will discover both our location in space and the interstellar subspace drive in its finished form. After that, they can get at *us*!"

"The opposite extreme of my dilemma," confirmed Zoya.

"Silence!" ordered Ahnu. "Let me think!"

All of them—Supervisor, assistant, technicians, and the image on the screen—considered the situation gloomily. The government of Yaradir would take a dry view of having to combat an invasion, should one develop from this. The race of Yaradir, because of their personal requirements and life conditions, were not as numerous as most of the races they had found in their explorations. The great distances between their colonies and the growing number of these were due to the comparative rarity of the type of planet that suited them.

"Can you reach the ship in your local rocket in time to escape in it?" asked Ahnu. "After all, subspace ships are costly; if we leave a deserted base, what can they find out?"

"It is possible," admitted Zoya doubtfully, "but risky."

"What do you mean?"

"They may intercept me on the way, for their ships are faster than my rocket. They may even catch the big ship before I gain enough speed to shift into subspace drive."

"For all we know," interrupted Ullo, forgetting his place, "they may be able to keep up with you even then."

Ahnu bubbled angrily at the idea, but they all were silent for another unhappy period of cogitation.

"Perhaps," admitted Ahnu in the end, "you will have to destroy the subspace ship, but only in the last extremity!"

"I could blow it up from space, if I get within range."

"Not so fast; that ship is a major item in the budget!" Ahnu told him angrily.

"The first thing is to try to get aboard unseen and return to pick up what you can from your base."

"And if these *Earthmen* are nearby?" Ullo asked.

"Then Zoya must forget the base and escape with the ship, which is the main thing."

"But if they have already found it?" inquired Zoya.

"All right, all right! *Then* destroy it! And you had better start immediately unless you wish to find such action necessary. Somehow,"—here one eyestalk was deflected rather pointedly toward Ullo—"somehow, too many mouths always speed up the clocks."

Ullo did a little neck-swelling himself at this example of bias.

Just because he couldn't get my job for his youngest brother, he thought resentfully. Serve him right if I'd resigned! Where'd he be if I didn't stick here to push his snout into the obvious every time he slides over it?

"Yes," repeated Ahnu, complacent at having found his solution, "that is what you must do. If anything goes wrong, you can still use your rocket to return to your base."

"Which I hope," sighed Zoya, "to find undisturbed."

At that, Ahnu fell silent. After a tense moment, he heaved himself around to direct both eyestalks at Ullo.

"Well?" he wheezed. "Have you no suggestions in case he does have to destroy the subspace ship?"

Ullo twirled one tentacle tip in the mud of his tub until he collected a sticky blob. This he flipped away with a snap of the tentacle. He derived a slight satisfaction from the *splat* against the far wall.

"We must try to preserve *one* of his collections of information," he said. "It would entail considerable expense—not to mention time—to replace Zoya and repeat the scouting."

Ahnu shifted his position irritably. Ullo saw that his reference to expense had been a shrewd blow. The Supervisor snorted and bubbled, but finally conceded that much and gestured for Ullo to continue.

"So it would be unfortunate if he should succeed in regaining his big ship, only to return to his base and find it occupied by exploring *Earthmen*."

"What do you suggest, then?"

"He should try for *either* the base or the ship, and arrange to destroy the other! If he can remain undetected for a short time at the base, he can dispose of his specimens after forwarding a report on them. If he gets to the ship safely, why leave behind any clues at all?"

After considerable wheezing and puffing, it was agreed that Zoya should take a chance on having his base discovered while he was away, but provide for the eventuality by arranging a bomb that would be set off by the approach of any strange ship. He admitted that he already had one, keyed to be safe only after certain signals from his own rocket. He had only to hook it up.

"If you do have to return," advised Ullo, "clean out your dissecting room and then make friends with the *Earthmen*. Give them some story of being cast away, and ask help in building a new ship."

"You mean ... install our kind of drive without their knowing?"

"Exactly!" said Ahnu, taking to the idea. "Then just drop out of sight some fine day and leave them wondering which way you went."

At this point, Viri made bold to request that Zoya leave the televisor at the base operating, with a continuous view of the main chamber as now shown. He began to explain that he wanted to be sure not to lose contact, but Ahnu had heard enough. He cut Viri short by climbing out of his mud tub.

"That settles it then," he summed up to Zoya. "If you *are* forced to destroy the subspace ship, report from the base when you return and are ready to contact the natives. Otherwise, report from the ship!"

He waddled out of the communications chamber without ceremony, followed by Ullo Dah-Gow.

The next day, the latter was kept busy with the many reports of arid planets he had to file in order to justify the expenses of exploration.

He always leaves explaining the budget to me, he thought.

He did, however, snatch time to put a copy tape of the last installment of Zoya's preliminary report on the speaker, having felt ill at ease for not being completely up to date at the previous evening's conference.

Halfway through a listing of sociological and psychological observations, Ullo stiffened. He ran the tape through again.

"He'd *better* get to that ship!" he wheezed to himself. "They sound like a nest of trouble-makers—resourceful, aggressive, just the sort to burst into this system some sweet day and tell us Yaradir is *their* colony!"

He ripped the tape out of the speaker and hurried along a dank corridor to Ahnu's office, not even pausing at his favorite spots to rub against the cool, dripping walls. He found his chief relaxing in an adjoining chamber by submitting to a massage.

"Not now!" complained Ahnu at the first mention of *Earthmen*. "Wait till we hear from Zoya. I want to enjoy having my scales oiled in peace!"

Ullo spitefully dropped the tape into a pot of scale-grease on the way out, but dutifully returned to his work.

Late one night, however, he was reminded of the scout in system LL-255-13. The emergency buzzer beside his sleeping pool awoke him with an urgent summons. The number on the screen beside it indicated the communications chamber now reserved for Zoya Lar-Tul.

Still dripping, Ullo pumped down the corridor, encountering his chief at the last turn. Ahnu was irritated.

"What can they have spoiled now?" he demanded, as if he suspected Ullo of having had a tentacle in it. "It was a perfectly simple arrangement!"

"Perhaps something unexpected came up," suggested Ullo.

"What could be unexpected? It was utterly simple!" said Ahnu explosively. "If he beats them to it, he reports from the ship. Otherwise he destroys it and goes back to report from his base!"

He slap-slapped irately into their destination, wondering audibly why he had to come down here and direct people's eyestalks for them.

"Because, Great One," replied Viri Nol-Rin, a trifle more abruptly than was consistent with proper respect for Ahnu's position, "the televisor at Zoya's base has gone dead!"

"What? Why? If you can't keep in communication—"

"There *isn't* any communication," interrupted Viri.

Ullo saw that the operator was deeply disturbed. To interrupt—*actually interrupt*—Ahnu Nol-Yev! Even if one was his nephew!

"That is why, if you will remember," Viri went on, "I insisted Zoya leave his signal in operation. The chance that his base would be approached by a strange ship sooner than we hoped, and blow up."

"So the bomb went off?" said Ullo.

"It must have. And, by the figures Zoya gave me before he left, he is long, long overdue at the subspace ship."

"Well, what of it?" demanded Ahnu. "It merely means he will have to report from the ship when he ... if he ... if *they* don't—"

He snorted and wheezed into silence.

Ullo traded stares with Viri. Then he looked at Yado, who wore an equally unhappy expression on his wide visage.

"Are you *sure* he would have reached the ship before now?" Ahnu demanded.

"Completely."

The Supervisor swore feelingly, using some of the bleakest and driest terms Ullo had ever heard. The gist of the diatribe was the delay and expense.

"Now it may be yaras before we get his data!"

"How do you mean?" asked Ullo.

"It's obvious, isn't it? He must have had to destroy the ship; but before he got back, some prowling *Earthmen* set off the charge at his base. That leaves him with only his rocket. Don't you see what it means?"

"Perhaps not," said Ullo.

"Why, he'll have to make friends with those *things* from *Earth*, and get help building a new ship. Until then, we'll have to classify his report 'pending.'"

He sloshed watery mud about as he heaved himself from his tub impatiently. Ullo aimed an eyestalk at each of the technicians, keeping them silent until Ahnu had waddled indignantly from the room.

"I *knew* we didn't cover all the alternatives that night!" said Ullo feelingly. "How could we be so dry inside the skull? How *could* we?"

"He certainly doesn't like the delay," commented Yado.

"Delay!" snorted Ullo. Then he asked, "Is that what it means to you, too?"

Viri and Yado fidgeted under his stare.

"I keep wondering if Zoya reached the ship," said Ullo.

They stared at him.

"Say it this way, then: 'If Zoya reached the ship?'"

Viri sighed.

"I suppose we may never find out what really happened," he said.

"I believe I would really rather *not*," Ullo told them, preparing to leave. "Listen in to a complete copy of the preliminary report Zoya sent, and you will see what I mean."

His scales were too dry and needed an oiling, he told himself; but he knew it was more than that which sent the shudder through him. And there were *billions* of them!

"What shall we do?" asked Viri.

"I don't know what good it will do," said Ullo, pausing in the doorway, "but you might make your wills. Personally, I intend to apply for transfer to some colony lying in the opposite direction from this *Sol*. Record of us, and a ship to reach us—we might as well have sent them an invitation!"

He remembered their unhappy eyes two yaras later, when the regular bulletin tapes sent out to the colonies reported Ahnu's dismissal. Ullo applied for a post at a more distant colony.

After one yara at the new post, the monthly tapes from Yaradir were interrupted. Everybody complained about the service.

Everybody but Ullo.

He commandeered a subspace ship, and moved on.

But not ... far ... enough....

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